FOR TEACHERS ONLY

The University of the State of New York
REGENTS HIGH SCHOOL EXAMINATION

PHYSICAL SETTING/EARTH SCIENCE

Friday, January 23, 2026 — 9:15 a.m. to 12:15 p.m., only

RATING GUIDE

Directions to the Teacher:

Refer to the directions on page 2 before rating student papers.

Updated information regarding the rating of this examination may be posted on the New York State Education Department's web site during the rating period. Check this web site at: https://www.nysed.gov/state-assessment/high-school-regents-examinations and select the link "Scoring Information" for any recently posted information regarding this examination. This site should be checked before the rating process for this examination begins and several times throughout the Regents Examination period.

Directions to the Teacher

Follow the procedures below for scoring student answer papers for the Regents Examination in Physical Setting/Earth Science. Additional information about scoring is provided in the publication *Directions for Scoring Regents Examinations*.

Allow 1 credit for each correct response.

At least two science teachers must participate in the scoring of the Part B–2 and Part C open-ended questions on a student's paper. Each of these teachers should be responsible for scoring a selected number of the open-ended questions on each answer paper. No one teacher is to score more than approximately one-half of the open-ended questions on a student's answer paper. Teachers may not score their own students' answer papers.

Students' responses must be scored strictly according to the Rating Guide. For open-ended questions, credit may be allowed for responses other than those given in the rating guide if the response is a scientifically accurate answer to the question and demonstrates adequate knowledge as indicated by the examples in the rating guide. Do not attempt to correct the student's work by making insertions or changes of any kind. On the student's separate answer sheet, for each question, record the number of credits earned and the teacher's assigned rater/scorer letter.

Fractional credit is *not* allowed. Only whole-number credit may be given for a response. If the student gives more than one answer to a question, only the first answer should be rated. Units need not be given when the wording of the questions allows such omissions.

For hand scoring, raters should enter the scores earned in the appropriate boxes printed on the separate answer sheet. Next, the rater should add these scores and enter the total in the space provided. The student's score for the Earth Science Performance Test should be recorded in the space provided. Then the student's raw scores on the written test and the performance test should be converted to a scale score by using the conversion chart that will be posted on the Department's web site at: https://www.nysed.gov/state-assessment/high-school-regents-examinations on Friday, January 23, 2026. The student's scale score should be entered in the box labeled "Scale Score" on the student's answer sheet. The scale score is the student's final examination score.

Schools are not permitted to rescore any of the open-ended questions on this exam after each question has been rated once, regardless of the final exam score. Schools are required to ensure that the raw scores have been added correctly and that the resulting scale score has been determined accurately.

Because scale scores corresponding to raw scores in the conversion chart may change from one administration to another, it is crucial that, for each administration, the conversion chart provided for that administration be used to determine the student's final score.

Part B–2

Allow a maximum of 15 credits for this part.

To ensure the accuracy of overlays, select a printer setting such as *full, actual size,* or *100%* when printing this document. Do ***not*** select the *fit to page* setting.

51 [1] Allow 1 credit. Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

— The gravitational force increases from location *A* to perihelion, and then decreases form perihelion to location *A*.

— increases, then decreases

— gets greater, then it gets less

— As the comet gets closer to the Sun, the force gets stronger; as the comet gets farther from the Sun, the force gets weaker.

52 [1] Allow 1 credit for *two* correct responses. Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

Mass:

— mass is greater

— larger

— more

— Jovian planets have a greater mass.

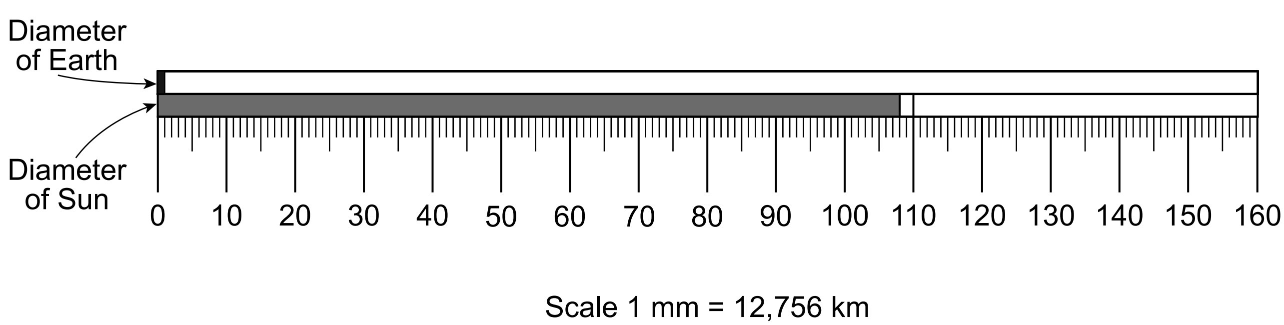
Density:

— smaller

— less

— Terrestrial planets have a greater density.

53 [1] Allow 1 credit for shading the bar labeled "Diameter of Sun" that ends in the clear rectangle area from 108 mm to 110 mm, as shown below:



Note: Allow 1 credit for a student answer that correctly marks the diameter of the Sun even if the area is not shaded between zero and their mark.

54 [1] Allow 1 credit. Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

— The velocity of the river is greater at location *B* so the water can carry larger and more particles.

— The velocity of the river is greater on the outside of the curve of the meander.

55 [1] Allow 1 credit. Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

— Particle size decreases as you travel farther off shore.

— Larger particles are deposited closer to the shoreline and smaller particles are deposited farther out.

— Sediments are deposited from larger to smaller sizes, horizontally .

56 [1] Allow 1 credit. Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

— The sediments become rounder by abrasion with other sediments.

— Sharp corners break off or wear off when they hit other rocks or sediments.

— Particles tumble, bounce, and roll along the bed of the river, chipping off parts to become rounder.

— Particles collide with other rock fragments or sediments.

Note: Do *not* allow credit for "water erosion" because "water" alone, without sediments, does *not* produce rounding.

57 [1] Allow 1 credit for a correct sequence, as shown below:

Y — Youngest ↑
X
V
Z
W — Oldest

58 [1] Allow 1 credit. Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

— Schist formed from the metamorphism of clay or feldspar under extreme heat and pressure.

— formed from the high temperature and pressure conditions

— regional metamorphism of slate and/or phyllite

59 [1] Allow 1 credit. Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

— They are distributed over a wide geographic area.

— They lived for a short period of time.

— easily recognizable

60 [1] Allow 1 credit for 40 ft.

61 [1] Allow 1 credit for north *or* northward.

62 [1] Allow 1 credit. Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

— The contour lines are closer together between points *C* and *D*.

— The contour lines are farther apart between points *A* and *B*.

— There are more contour lines between points *C* and *D*.

— There are more lines closer together.

63 [1] Allow 1 credit. Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

— During El Niño conditions, the trade winds become weaker.

— they become weaker

64 [1] Allow 1 credit. Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

— There is a higher air pressure over Australia during El Niño conditions and a lower air pressure over Australia during normal conditions.

— During normal conditions, Australia generally has low pressures, and during El Niño conditions the air pressure is greater.

65 [1] Allow 1 credit. Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

— Air expands and cools, causing water vapor to condense.

— Air is cooled to the dew point.

— Condensation occurs when the rising air reaches the dew point.

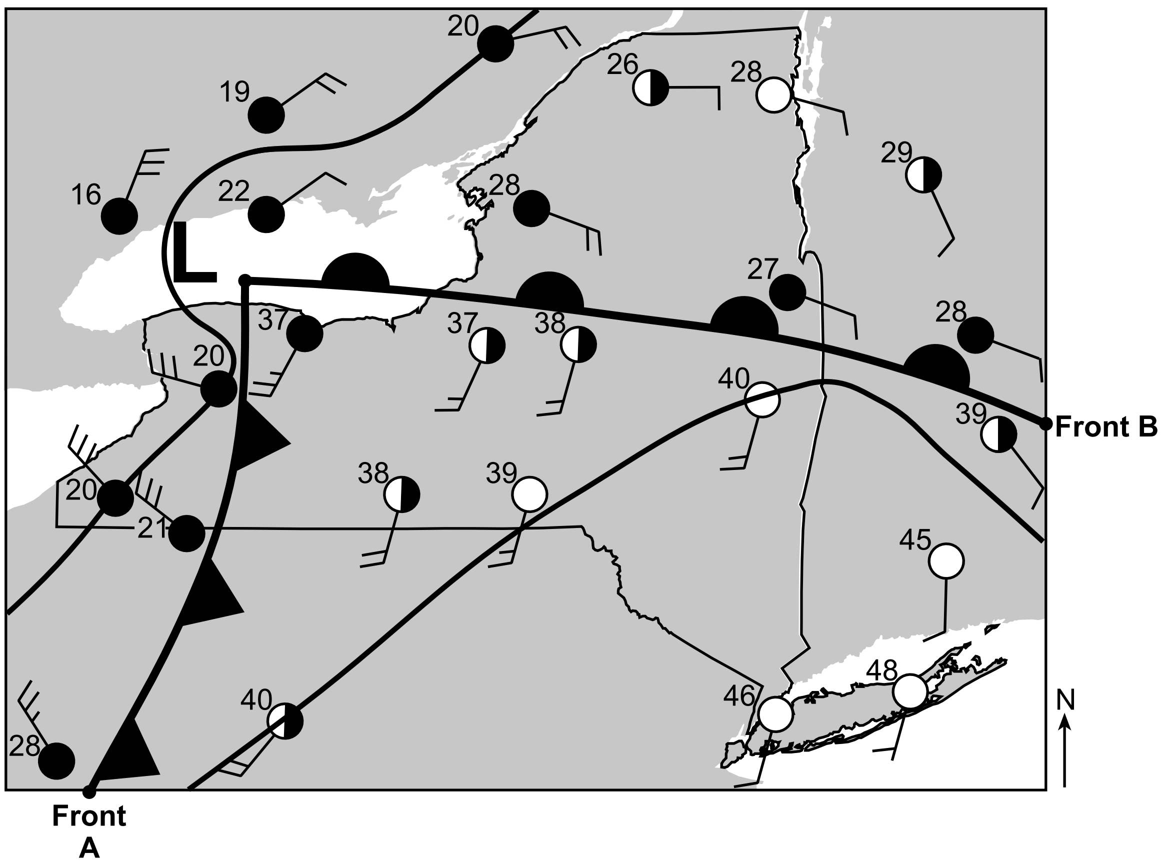
Part C

Allow a maximum of 20 credits for this part.

66 [1] Allow 1 credit for correctly drawing *both* isotherms extended to the edges of the map.

Note: If additional isotherms are drawn, all must be drawn correctly to receive credit. Allow credit if the student draws their lines through the numbers instead of through the center of the weather station model.

Example of a 1-credit response:



67 [1] Allow 1 credit for mT *or* cT. Allow credit for either uppercase or lowercase letters.

Note: Do *not* allow credit if air-mass letters are reversed, such as Tm. For students who used the Spanish edition, either exclusively or in conjunction with the English edition of the exam, allow credit for the correct two-letter air-mass symbol as it appears in either the English or Spanish *2011 Edition Reference Tables for Physical Setting/Earth Science*.

68 [1] Allow 1 credit if *both* responses are correct. Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

— Stock up on food and/or water.

— Obtain necessary prescription medications.

— Make sure emergency lighting/flashlights operate.

— Buy or change batteries for electronic devices.

— Make sure generator is working.

— Bring firewood indoors.

— Buy rock salt to melt ice on sidewalks.

— Check on elderly neighbors to see if they need assistance.

69 [1] Allow 1 credit for *two* correct responses. Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

— compaction

— cementation

— dewatering

— burial

Note: Do *not* allow credit for deposition or sedimentation, as the question states the sand grains have already been deposited.

70 [1] Allow 1 credit. Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

— The color of bluestone varies from greenish gray to grayish red purple.

— Bluestone isn't always blue in color.

— Bluestones occur in many colors.

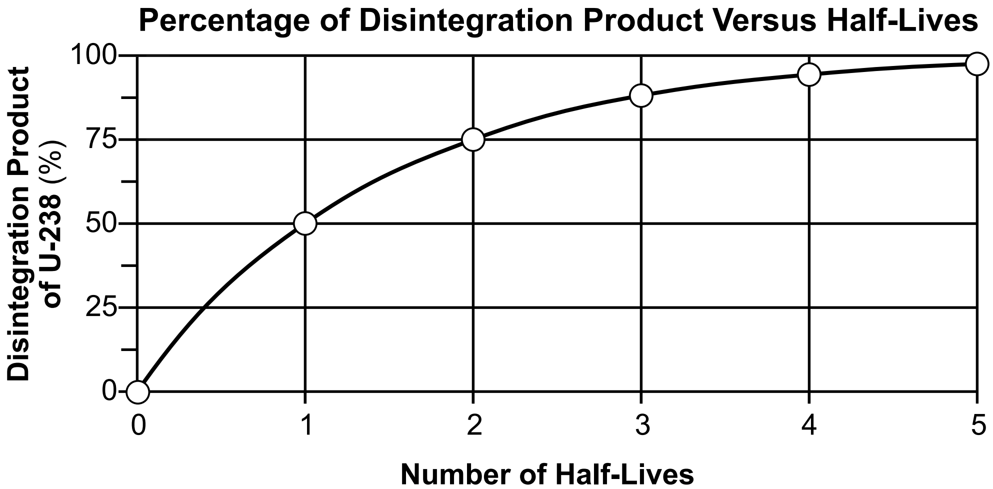
— Some other types of rock may have the same color as bluestone.

71 [1] Allow 1 credit for any value from 2 cm/s to 4 cm/s.

72 [1] Allow 1 credit for Allegheny Plateau *or* Appalachian Plateau (Uplands).

73 [1] Allow 1 credit if the centers of *all six* plots are within or touch the circles shown and *all six* plots are correctly connected with a line that passes within or touches each circle.

Example of a 1-credit response:



Note: Allow credit if the student-drawn line does not pass through the student plots, but is still within or touches the circles.

It is recommended that an overlay of the same scale as the student answer booklet be used to ensure reliability in rating.

74 [1] Allow 1 credit. Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

— As the amount of original radioactive isotope decreases, over time, the amount of disintegration product increases.

— The amount of disintegration product increases as the original isotope decays.

— inverse relationship/indirect relationship/negative correlation

75 [1] Allow 1 credit. Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

— lead-206

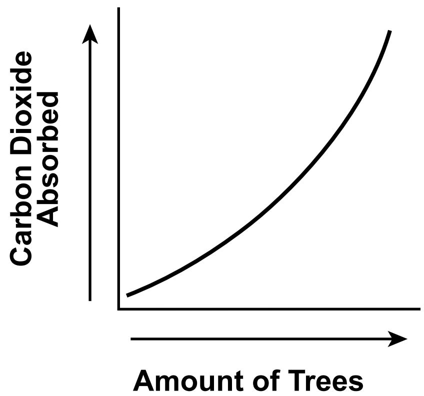
— ^{206}Pb

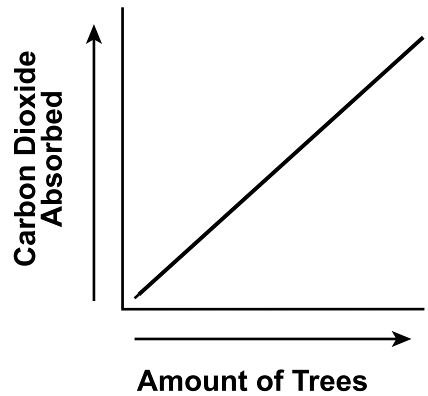
— Pb-206

Note: Do *not* allow credit for lead or Pb alone because lead has more than one isotope.

76 [1] Allow 1 credit for a line drawn that represents a direct relationship.

Examples of a 1-credit response:





77 [1] Allow 1 credit if *both* responses are correct. Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

Relative air temperature:

— The air temperature is greater.

— higher temperature

Relative humidity:

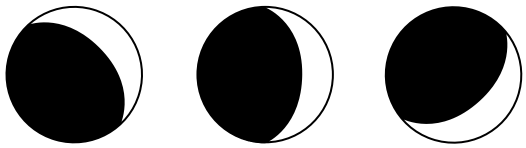
— low

— drier air

78 [1] Allow 1 credit for transpiration.

79 [1] Allow 1 credit if the student shades more than half of the Moon curving toward the lighted side, leaving a lighted crescent on the right edge, as shown below.

Examples of a 1-credit response:



80 [1] Allow 1 credit for *E*.

81 [1] Allow 1 credit for any value from 29 d to 30 d.

82 [1] Allow 1 credit. Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

— The Moon's rate of rotation is equal to its rate of revolution.

— For every one moon revolution it also rotates once.

— One spin on the Moon's axis takes the same time as one orbit around Earth.

83 [1] Allow 1 credit Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

— As latitude in the northern hemisphere increases, the number of daylight hours decreases.

— The duration of insolation will be shorter the farther north a location is from the Equator.

— indirect relationship/negative correlation/inverse relationship

84 [1] Allow 1 credit. Acceptable responses include, but are not limited to:

— The shadow length will decrease.

— The shadow will be shorter.

— become smaller

85 [1] Allow 1 credit for summer.

The *Chart for Determining the Final Examination Score for the January 2026 Regents Examination in Physical Setting/Earth Science* will be posted on the Department's web site at: https://www.nysed.gov/state-assessment/high-school-regents-examinations on Friday, January 23, 2026. Conversion charts provided for previous administrations of the Regents Examination in Physical Setting/Earth Science must NOT be used to determine students' final scores for this administration.

Online Submission of Teacher Evaluations of the Test to the Department

Suggestions and feedback from teachers provide an important contribution to the test development process. The Department provides an online evaluation form for State assessments. It contains spaces for teachers to respond to several specific questions and to make suggestions. Instructions for completing the evaluation form are as follows:

1. Go to https://www.nysed.gov/state-assessment/teacher-feedback-state-assessments.

2. Click Regents Examinations.

3. Complete the required demographic fields.

4. Select the test title from the Regents Examination dropdown list.

5. Complete each evaluation question and provide comments in the space provided.

6. Click the SUBMIT button at the bottom of the page to submit the completed form.

Map to Core Curriculum

January 2026 Physical Setting/Earth Science			
Question Numbers			
Key Ideas/Performance Indicators	Part A	Part B	Part C
Standard 1			
Math Key Idea 1	2	43	73, 76
Math Key Idea 2	21		71, 74, 76, 83
Math Key Idea 3		37, 53, 60	
Science Inquiry Key Idea 1	4, 6, 7, 15	50, 54, 56, 58, 59, 62, 65	70, 82
Science Inquiry Key Idea 2			
Science Inquiry Key Idea 3	9, 10, 11, 16, 18, 21, 23, 24, 25, 26, 28, 29, 30, 31, 34, 35	37, 39, 40, 41, 42, 45, 46, 50, 52, 53, 58	67, 69, 70, 71, 72, 75, 76, 82
Engineering Design Key Idea 1			
Standard 2			
Key Idea 1			
Key Idea 2			
Key Idea 3			
Standard 6			
Key Idea 1	27	38, 54, 55, 65	69, 77, 78
Key Idea 2	2, 5, 7, 8, 9, 10, 13, 17, 18, 19, 20, 30, 32, 33, 34, 35	36, 37, 39, 40, 43, 44, 45, 46, 47, 48, 49, 51, 54, 55, 57, 58, 60, 61, 62, 63, 64	66, 67, 72, 73, 74, 79, 80, 83, 85
Key Idea 3		53	
Key Idea 4		51	
Key Idea 5	2, 12, 19, 21, 23, 26	38, 43, 49, 51, 55, 56, 57, 62, 63, 64	66, 74, 79, 81, 83, 84
Key Idea 6			
Standard 7			
Key Idea 1			
Key Idea 2			68
Standard 4			
Key Idea 1	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 10, 18, 19, 21, 22, 23	43, 44, 45, 46, 47, 48, 51, 52, 53, 57, 59	73, 74, 75, 78, 79, 80, 81, 82, 83, 84, 85
Key Idea 2	9, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 20, 24, 25, 26, 27, 31, 32, 33, 34	36, 37, 38, 39, 40, 42, 49, 50, 54, 55, 56, 60, 61, 62, 63, 64, 65	66, 67, 68, 71, 72, 76, 77
Key Idea 3	28, 29, 30, 35	41, 58	69, 70
Reference Tables			
ESRT 2011 Edition (Revised)	9, 10, 11, 16, 18, 21, 22, 24, 25, 26, 28, 29, 30, 31, 34, 35	37, 39, 40, 41, 42, 45, 46, 50, 52, 53, 58	67, 69, 71, 72, 75, 82